

50 Excel Shortcuts Worth Learning

The shortcuts that actually save time —
no macros, no VBA, just keys.

Before we start

Shortcuts shown are for Windows Excel. On Mac, replace Ctrl with Cmd in most cases (Alt often becomes Option). You don't need all 50 memorised — Section 8 lists the five worth learning first if you only have ten minutes.

1. Moving around fast

Shortcut	What it does
Ctrl + Arrow key	Jump to the edge of the current data block in that direction
Ctrl + Home	Jump to cell A1
Ctrl + End	Jump to the last used cell in the sheet
Ctrl + Page Up / Page Down	Switch between sheet tabs
Ctrl + G or F5	Open Go To — jump to a specific cell reference
Ctrl + F	Find
Ctrl + H	Find and Replace
Tab / Shift + Tab	Move one cell right / left

2. Selecting without dragging

Shortcut	What it does
Ctrl + Shift + Arrow key	Extend selection to the edge of the data block
Ctrl + A	Select the entire data region (press twice for the whole sheet)
Ctrl + Space	Select the entire column
Shift + Space	Select the entire row
Ctrl + Shift + End	Select from current cell to the last used cell
Ctrl + Click	Add non-adjacent cells to a selection

3. Editing faster

Shortcut	What it does
Ctrl + D	Fill down — copy the cell above into the selection
Ctrl + R	Fill right — copy the cell to the left into the selection
Ctrl + ;	Insert today's date
Ctrl + Shift + ;	Insert the current time
Alt + Enter	Start a new line inside the same cell
F2	Edit the active cell directly
Ctrl + Z / Ctrl + Y	Undo / Redo
Delete	Clear cell contents (keeps formatting)
Ctrl + - (minus)	Delete selected cells/rows/columns
Ctrl + + (plus)	Insert cells/rows/columns

4. Formatting without the mouse

Shortcut	What it does
Ctrl + B / I / U	Bold / Italic / Underline
Ctrl + 1	Open Format Cells dialog
Ctrl + Shift + \$	Apply currency format
Ctrl + Shift + %	Apply percentage format
Ctrl + Shift + #	Apply date format
Ctrl + Shift + ~	Apply general (default) number format
Alt + H, H	Open the fill colour menu (via Ribbon shortcut keys)

5. Formulas and calculation

Shortcut	What it does
Ctrl + ` (grave accent)	Toggle between showing formulas and showing values
F4	Toggle absolute/relative references (\$A\$1 vs A1) while editing a formula
Alt + =	Auto-sum the selected range
Ctrl + Shift + Enter	Confirm a formula as an array formula (older Excel versions)
F9	Recalculate all open workbooks
Shift + F9	Recalculate only the active sheet
Ctrl + [	Trace precedents — jump to cells this formula depends on

6. Working with data and tables

Shortcut	What it does
Ctrl + T	Convert a data range into a formatted Table
Ctrl + Shift + L	Toggle AutoFilter on the selected range
Alt + D, P	Open the PivotTable and PivotChart Wizard
Ctrl + Alt + F5	Refresh all data connections and pivot tables
Ctrl + Shift + &	Apply an outline border to the selection
Ctrl + Shift + _	Remove all borders from the selection

7. Workbook and file management

Shortcut	What it does
Ctrl + N	New workbook
Ctrl + S	Save
F12	Save As
Ctrl + P	Print
Ctrl + W	Close the current workbook
Shift + F11	Insert a new sheet
Ctrl + Tab	Switch between open Excel windows
Alt + Tab	Switch between open applications (Windows-level, not Excel-specific)
Ctrl + Mouse wheel	Zoom in/out

8. If you only learn five

- **Ctrl + Arrow key** — instantly navigate large datasets without scrolling.
- **Ctrl + Shift + Arrow key** — select entire data ranges in one motion instead of dragging.
- **F4** — lock formula references without retyping dollar signs by hand.
- **Ctrl + D / Ctrl + R** — fill formulas down or across in one keystroke.
- **Alt + =** — auto-sum a column or row instantly.

Shortcuts shown reflect common Excel behaviour and can vary slightly by version and regional keyboard layout — if one doesn't fire, check your Excel version's shortcut reference.